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Power, Knowledge, and the Remaking of a Field: A Critical Reading of Critical Approaches to Science and Religion

Historically, the debate between science and religion has been framed as a conceptual conflict: two systems of knowledge, one empirical and one of revelation, competing for intellectual authority. But this framing has been challenged by scholars who argue that it obscures far more than it clarifies. The volume *Critical Approaches to Science and Religion*, edited by Myrna Perez Sheldon, Ahmed Ragab, and Terence Keel, is a significant contribution to this debate. Instead of posing the question of science and religion as one of either conflict or harmony, the volume presents a different set of questions: "How have histories of slavery, patriarchy, and colonialism shaped the emergence of science and religion in modernity?" (Sheldon et al. 1). This report argues that *Critical Approaches to Science and Religion* fundamentally redefines the field by centering feminist, queer, and postcolonial frameworks, moving the field from a philosophical discussion of ideas to a historically grounded analysis of how power shapes the production of knowledge.

The most significant contribution of this volume is methodological. Historically, the field of science and religion studies has been defined by two opposing sides. The first is the conflict thesis, proposed by nineteenth-century historians such as John William Draper and Andrew Dickson White, which states that "science and religion constitute timeless and irreconcilable ways of knowing the natural world" (Sheldon et al. 1). The second are the various harmony or dialogue models, which the editors refer to as the "complexity thesis": scholars who "argued that the historically contingent nature of these two ways of knowing makes any one descriptive metaphor for their relationship an inadequate distortion" (Sheldon et al. 1-2). Both framings, as the authors suggest in their introduction, share a common assumption: that science and religion are stable, coherent, and in essence ahistorical categories whose relationship can be evaluated in the abstract. This volume entirely rejects that premise.

Instead, the editors propose a methodological approach based on social, political, and ecological concerns. Science and religion are not treated as permanent intellectual traditions but as historically constructed categories whose definitions have been contested, weaponized, and revised in response to particular political and social pressures. As the editors explain, their "perspective centers histories of patriarchy, slavery, and colonialism in an analysis of science and religion in order to clarify the effects and lived experiences of both categories" (Sheldon et al. 2). This critical lens, they argue, "reveals how science and religion emerged alongside—and, indeed, constitute—modern power structures and identities, and, in turn, undergirded the emergence of race, gender, sexuality, class, and nationality in the modern world" (Sheldon et al. 2). By putting social and political issues at the center of the field, one does not merely contextualize a philosophical debate; one insists that the debate can only be understood in terms of the power relations that produced it. The editors are explicit that they seek "the willingness to use historical insight to engage in contemporary political and social struggle,"

going beyond what either the conflict or complexity thesis was "designed to provide" (Sheldon et al. 2).

The volume covers a range of critical theoretical perspectives, but two are particularly influential for the essays collected here: feminist and queer theory and postcolonial theory. Together, the editors explain, these frameworks form the basis for "a critical approach to the study of science and religion" that centers the "raced, gendered, sexualized, and colonized natures of science and religion" (Sheldon et al. 4). Each one provides a distinct view of the history of science and religion kept in the dark by mainstream scholarship.

Feminist and queer theory explore how categories of sex, gender, and sexuality are constructed and standardized, along with how scientific and religious authority have worked together historically to do so. The editors draw on feminist science studies to show that "the very definition of science—its empiricism, rationality, and objectivity—was tied to arguments that only masculine intellects were capable of science," a circular definition that "excluded women from its practices and its category" (Sheldon et al. 5-6). One result of this, they argue, has been "the feminization of religion as modern science's problematic other," such that religious belief came to be portrayed as "the cowardly purview of feminized minds", a framing that also served to mark "nearly all nonwhite European peoples" as incapable of rational inquiry (Sheldon et al. 6). In "A Feminist Theology of Abortion," Myrna Perez Sheldon demonstrates these dynamics effectively, tracing how both science and religion have jointly governed women's reproductive bodies throughout American history. She shows how both Catholic authorities and Evangelical leaders alike built their opposition to abortion on a "heteronormative and patriarchal view[s] of sexuality," while scientific authorities in medicine and eugenics simultaneously developed frameworks that treated reproduction as a population management problem (Sheldon 66). The result, as Sheldon argues, is that "the confidence that scientific knowledge was the means by which humanity could engineer its own progress" became intertwined with theological claims about sexuality and personhood, the two systems reinforcing each other rather than opposing each other (Sheldon 73). The feminist contributors to the volume suggest that to destabilize this network, one must give attention to both its scientific and religious roots simultaneously, a task for which neither feminist science nor feminist theology is sufficiently prepared to handle.

Postcolonial theory, meanwhile, emphasizes the role that the categories of science and religion have played in managing colonial differences. The editors argue that "secularization narratives cast Eastern religions (such as Islam and Hinduism) and Indigenous cultures as inadequately evolved in relation to Western religion and, subsequently, to science," with Western elites claiming that "science was both universally true and the exclusive property of Euro-America" (Sheldon et al. 6). One of the volume's most important insights, made explicit in the introduction, is that the scholarly "theses of conflict and conciliation are no longer abstract methods by which to understand how science and religion interact but are, in fact, paradigm-making concepts that attempt to define the postcolonial subjects and their relationship to Western power and its traditions" (Sheldon et al. 7). Tisa Wenger's chapter "Spiriting the Johnstons" develops this argument through the history of Anishinaabe peoples in the early nineteenth-century United States. Wenger demonstrates that "science and religion were coconstituted in the interests of U.S. colonial rule": European and U.S. colonizers "named the traditions of colonized peoples 'religion' only to relegate them to an outmoded, primitive past while identifying themselves as modern because they had advanced either to the superior

religion of Christianity or beyond it to master secular or scientific reason" (Wenger 106). Under this arrangement, Wenger shows, "science facilitated the extraction of resources from colonized lands" while "religion fostered the illusion of settler benevolence even as it mopped up and papered over the violence of conquest" (Wenger 106). This sorting of Indigenous knowledge into the category of "religion" was, as Wenger makes clear, not a neutral act of classification but a political operation that justified the displacement of Indigenous knowledge and the establishment of Western intellectual authority.

In the case studies of the volume, one observes a consistent pattern: power does not simply distort knowledge from the outside as an external force that biases otherwise neutral analysis. Rather, power is an integral component of knowledge, shaping what questions are asked, what methods are considered acceptable, and which populations' lived experiences are taken as evidence. Three chapters in particular convey this dynamic with clarity and force.

The entanglement of science and religion with empire is a recurring theme. Wenger's account of Henry Rowe Schoolcraft is instructive: his "enlightened explorations in geology, ethnology, philology, and religion served the clear purpose of mapping resources—mineral, biological, and human—for colonial extraction and control" (Wenger 105-106). Wenger argues that this entanglement was not merely institutional but systematic, with science and religion jointly functioning as "instruments for colonial control" even as they appeared to be in opposition to each other (Wenger 106). The distinctions between these fields, "their collaborations as well as their apparent oppositions, developed historically within an imperial frame" (Wenger 106). Religion, in Wenger's telling, "was a feminine virtue and a resource for governing inferiors," while scientific rationality was reserved for the white settler patriarch—both serving the same colonial function (Wenger 112).

The connection between science, religion, and slavery is examined directly in Suman Seth's "Performing Polygenism." Seth traces how American polygenist physician Josiah Nott used natural history to argue that Caucasians were natural rulers and that "no philanthropy, no legislation, no missionary labours can change this law" (Seth 230). Seth argues that "polygenist science, for the American school of anthropology, could serve very explicitly as a tool for the defense of the South's peculiar institution," with the categories of natural history and biblical interpretation working together to produce racial hierarchy as an apparent fact (Seth 230). As Seth draws on Terence Keel to note, however, polygenism was not simply an ideological cover for slavery: Nott was also "driven to his position by what he understood to be scientific interests," which means that racial science and proslavery religion were genuinely intertwined rather than one being a mask for the other (Seth 231). The case studies, Seth shows, reveal the underlying mechanisms of generating knowledge that continue to influence contemporary science in rarely acknowledged ways.

A third focus is the governance of women's bodies by the joint authority of science and religion. Sheldon's chapter on abortion demonstrates this pattern over more than a century of American history. She shows how medical and eugenic authorities developed frameworks that "treated reproduction as a population management problem" while religious authorities simultaneously built moral arguments around sexuality and personhood, the two traditions reinforcing each other even when they appeared to disagree (Sheldon 73). Sheldon traces how Catholic and Evangelical institutions used theological frameworks that positioned women's bodies as objects of moral governance, while scientific institutions used medical and

demographic frameworks that positioned them as objects of population management. "What threaded through these disparate movements," Sheldon argues, "was the confidence that scientific knowledge was the means by which humanity could engineer its own progress", a confidence that was always also a confidence in the governance of women's bodies (Sheldon 73). The pattern that emerges across Wenger, Seth, and Sheldon is consistent: wherever we find the joint authority of science and religion, we tend to find the subordination of populations deemed closer to nature, further from reason, and in need of governance by those positioned as fully rational.

This is not only a volume of historical scholarship but also one that is motivated by a sense of urgency regarding the crises of the present day. Climate change may be the best example of how the critical frameworks developed in the volume help shed light on contemporary problems in ways that conventional science-religion discourse cannot.

The mainstream science-religion debate on climate change has mostly centered on whether religious communities accept or reject the scientific consensus, a framing that replicates the conflict/harmony polarity that the volume rejects. What the postcolonial and feminist frameworks developed in the volume reveal is a much more complex and troubling picture. Eli Nelson's chapter on "Kānaka Maoli Voyaging Technology and Geography Beyond Colonial Difference" is the volume's most direct engagement with these issues. Nelson argues that the battle over the Thirty Meter Telescope on Mauna Kea is not a conflict between science and religion but rather "political and epistemological—pitting Indigenous epistemologies, relations, and sovereignty against settler science, religion, and occupation" (Nelson 282). He observes that "Indigenous animism is still framed as an inhibiting moral and religious check on science, not as a political ideology and epistemology in the same sphere," even as "climate change continues to reveal the destructive nature of objectivism" that settler science relies on (Nelson 282). In other words, the very epistemic hierarchy that dismisses Kānaka ecological knowledge as "religion" is the same one that has failed to produce adequate responses to climate change.

Erika Lorraine Milam's chapter "Secular Grace in the Age of Environmentalism" further illustrates the gendered and racialized aspects of environmental knowledge. Milam shows that the scientific celebrity of figures like Jane Goodall and Dian Fossey depended on their roles as "white, female intermediaries between the perceived civilization of their viewers and the tropical wilderness through which they trekked" (Milam 208, citing Haraway). In this framing, "local residents were often framed as threatening the integrity of the land and its animal inhabitants," even though, as Milam insists, "marginalized and colonized peoples have long traditions of reflecting on and engaging with nature" (Milam 209). Together, Nelson and Milam suggest that engaging with climate change cannot be detached from engaging with the systematic injustices that have structured the production of environmental knowledge. To recognize ecological concerns, as the editors suggest in the introduction, is to take climate science seriously but also to consider whose understanding of the environment has been deemed legitimate and whose has been dismissed as superstition or sentiment.

Critical Approaches to Science and Religion is a significant and timely intervention in a field that has too often distanced itself from the broader currents of critical scholarship. The greatest strength of the volume is the range and diversity of its case studies, which collectively demonstrate that the entanglement of science and religion within structures of power is the rule

rather than the exception. The volume is not simply adding new material to existing frameworks; it is challenging the frameworks themselves, contending that the field cannot be reformed from within its own preconceptions. As the editors acknowledge, their aim is not "merely a new and lasting methodological validity" but something more politically urgent: the ability to address "contemporary political and social struggle" through historical analysis (Sheldon et al. 2).

The volume also raises new and underexplored questions. If science and religion are colonial and patriarchal constructions, what does it mean to do science-and-religion studies from outside those categories? How can scholarship in this field engage with indigenous knowledge traditions or non-Western cosmological systems in ways that do not merely reclaim them as exotic variations on Western themes? The editors acknowledge that they are beginning "a conversation that is intended to be promising and provocative rather than exhaustive," and that expanding and transforming the field is a goal rather than an accomplished fact (Sheldon et al. 4). These questions are opened by the volume but not resolved, and this is appropriate: answering them is the work of the next generation of scholarship that this volume helps make possible.

That said, the volume is not without its limitations. The most significant limitation is a stronger investment in critique than in construction. The essays are consistently effective in demonstrating how power has shaped knowledge, but they are less developed in formulating what a more just order would look like or how it might be built. Related to this is the problem of conceptual uniformity: when all the case studies are arranged around the same core principles (power, knowledge, empire, race, and gender), the framework risks formulating the answer before the evidence has been examined. This is not a problem unique to this volume, but one that will have to be addressed in future work on this topic. Finally, the theoretical density of the volume, while appropriate for professional audiences, may limit its reach beyond academic circles, a point worth noting given its stated political ambitions.

These caveats do not detract from the achievement of the volume. *Critical Approaches to Science and Religion* is not just another contribution to an ongoing discussion; it changes the terms of that discussion. In doing so, it offers scholars, students, and interested readers not only a more transparent account of the way science and religion have operated in the past but also a more powerful means for understanding and addressing the crises they face today.

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